

to others, I realized choices varied considerably. There is no magic bullet or seven-step process to follow. Despite the differences in methods employed to achieve FI, there are common patterns and traits repeatedly demonstrated by those who *Choose FI*. Possibly the most important is having a growth mindset.

Carol Dweck is a psychologist at Stanford University who writes and teaches about differences between a “fixed mindset” and a “growth mindset.” According to Dweck, those with a fixed mindset believe success is based on innate ability, while those with a growth mindset believe that success is a result of continued learning, personal development, and persistence. Those with a fixed mindset tend to fear failure, which would reflect negatively on them. This leads to insecurity, masked by avoiding challenging situations to try to make themselves look good. In contrast, those with a growth mindset embrace challenges, recognizing that growth and development are results of discomfort, uncertainty, and learning from failure. Developing a growth mindset is common among those who *Choose FI*.

One of the first objections I hear when discussing FI with someone not familiar with the concept goes like this: “I would love to do that, but I don’t make enough money.” Another variation is, “That